Cambridge Assessment International Education

Cambridge O Level

ENGLISH LANGUAGE **1123/21**

Paper 2 Reading **October/November 2022**

INSERT **1 hour 45 minutes**

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INFORMATION

- This insert contains the reading passages.
- You may annotate this insert and use the blank spaces for planning. **Do not write your answers** on the insert.

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Passage 1

Paper

1 It is believed that the first production of paper occurred in China and was accidental; when clothes were left too long in water after washing, a residue formed which could then be pressed into a useful new material. There is archaeological evidence that paper made from rags – a combination of plants and old clothes and fabrics – was being deliberately manufactured for use by the Chinese military almost 3000 years ago. The first standardised and systematic papermaking process took place in China in the first century and is attributed to Cai Lun, an inventor who was responsible for standardising the composition of paper by adding the pulped bark of the mulberry tree to the traditional rags. The development of paper production continued in China as more and more uses for it were found; for example, the Song Dynasty was the first government to use paper as money and the Tang Dynasty invented teabags – folded paper sewn into squares which preserved the tea's flavour.

2 By the sixth century, papermaking techniques had spread from China to other countries, including Korea, Vietnam and Japan; the trip of a Korean Buddhist monk to Japan is often cited as the official beginning of papermaking there. When paper reached Arab countries, paper-making machines designed for bulk manufacturing were invented there and installed in factories in many cities, for example Baghdad, Damascus and Tripoli. Later, following the Arab invasion of the European continent, paper mills sprang up across Europe – the first of which was built in Spain – and soon paper was being made all over the continent. It was used for printing important books and contributed to the increase in learning in Europe. Preservation of these historic books must be continued if future generations are to appreciate them.

3 Before major industrialisation, paper was made mainly from rags. However, a further development in papermaking came about in the nineteenth century when only wood was used to make it. This method was favoured because wood was less expensive and more abundant than cloth. Another improvement which occurred during industrialisation was the development of a machine which could produce paper at high speed in large quantities, using a continuous belt to churn it out.

4 However, there are problems associated with paper production in modern times, and we are being urged to make and use less of it. The industry is heavily reliant on water; it is estimated that it takes more than three gallons of water to produce a single sheet of paper – although this water can be recycled. Because wood is used in modern paper production, forests have been cut down, reducing their diversity, and thus the variety of animal and plant life on earth. Education about wood conservation should take centre stage in all our schools. Although reforestation is practised in many areas so that trees are a renewable source, this is not happening everywhere. There is a preference for white paper, which is produced through bleaching. The harmful chemicals used to bleach paper have become a source of environmental concern so that, recently, paper manufacturers have been devising alternative whitening methods by using other chemicals.

5 In the fight against plastic, manufacturers are using paper instead of plastic packaging, paper cups and straws are replacing plastic ones, and we carry our groceries in paper bags. Although paper does eventually degrade, or break down naturally, unlike plastic which does not, there is still an environmental cost to filling our landfill sites with paper. We all need to think carefully about how we can minimise our use of paper. Furthermore, when paper degrades on a landfill site, it emits methane gas which is much more toxic than other greenhouse gases. Paper can be recycled, but the process has its drawbacks because de-inking – the industrial process of removing printing ink from the original paper – uses chemicals which damage the environment.

6 Over time, the production of increasingly vast amounts of paper for business uses, whether notes, files or reports, has led to massive problems in terms of the secure storage of confidential data. Nowadays, technology enables business to be conducted electronically, which in turn is reducing the demand for paper.

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Passage 2

A Retirement Adventure

1 When my wife and I retired from our busy jobs, our son expected us to settle into a quiet, uneventful life in the town where we had always lived.

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‘Our cooking isn’t up to restaurant standards,’ he said, ‘but we would be really happy if you would join us for dinner at our house on Saturday.’

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